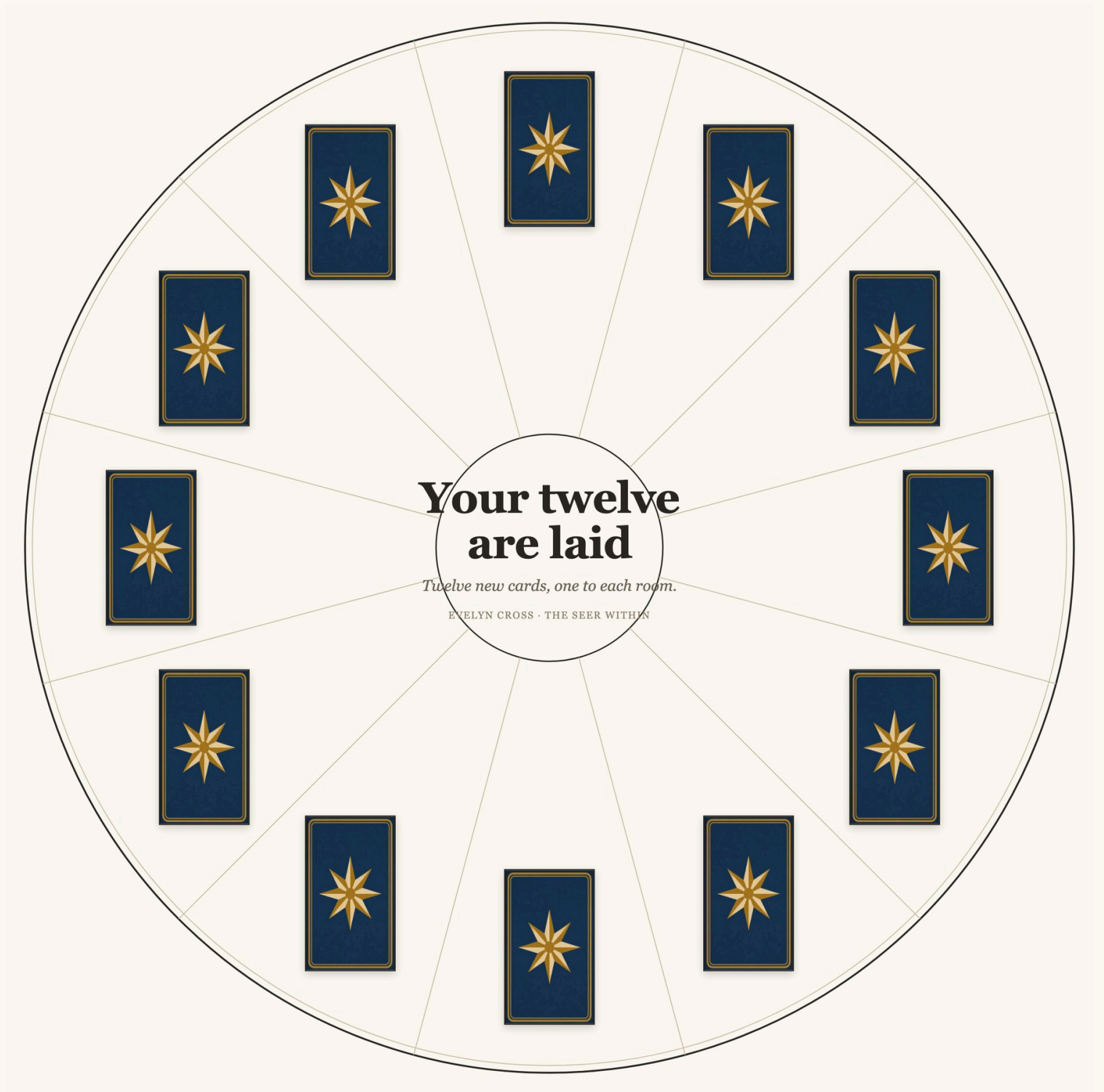




Laid for **Sarah** · 7 September 2026

YOUR TWELVE, AS THEY WERE LAID

A house is a room of a life. The wheel has twelve of them, and one card was laid in each — it is the oldest spread there is for reading a whole life rather than a single question.

The rooms come in **six pairs**, each one facing the room across the wheel from it: what you own faces what reaches you through other people, home faces your standing, romance faces your circle. Where a room below sends you across to another, that pairing is why.

- 1** **yourself** ↔ 7 *the Nameless One*
how you meet the world, and what starts with you
- 2** **what you own** ↔ 8 *the Wheel of Fortune*
money, and the things that are genuinely yours
- 3** **what you say, and who you say it to** ↔ 9 *the Sun*
conversations, messages, and the thing you rehearse and never send
- 4** **home, and what you came from** ↔ 10 *the Hierophant*
the house you live in, and the one you were raised in
- 5** **romance, and what delights you** ↔ 11 *the Magician*
attraction and pleasure — the beginning of things, before anything is settled
- 6** **work, health, the daily grind** ↔ 12 *the Chariot*
the ordinary week: the job, the body, the routine you repeat
- 7** **who you are bound to** ↔ 1 *Strength*
your partner, or whoever you are tied to whether or not it is called that
- 8** **what is hidden, and what comes through others** ↔ 2 *the Fool*
what reaches you through somebody else's hands — money, news, a decision made elsewhere
- 9** **what you believe** ↔ 3 *Judgment*
what you take to be true about how life works
- 10** **your standing** ↔ 4 *the Empress*
how you are seen, and by the people whose opinion counts
- 11** **your circle** ↔ 5 *Temperance*
your friends, and who actually turns up
- 12** **what is being kept from you** ↔ 6 *the High Priestess*
what is real and close, and not visible from where you are standing

The pair marker ↔ points to the room across the wheel. Nothing to learn — it is there so a line that sends you to another room makes sense when it does.

Dear Sarah,

I laid your twelve last night at the kitchen table, long after the rest of the house had gone quiet. Majors only, no minors, the way I told you I would do yours — it is the heaviest work I do, it costs me a full night, and I keep it for the women whose first draw asks for it. Yours asked twice.

It is a good draw. Not a soft one. The next two months are the window for all twelve of these, and inside those two months the real movement of your life happens in three rooms: your second, where money is; your fifth, where a man is; your twelfth, where the man already beside you is.

The one I sat with longest was your fifth. I could not begin writing it until nearly two in the morning, because the card standing there will not let me hand you renewal. It shuts a door I believe you have been holding open with your foot. Once I was certain, I wrote it out in full.

Everything the two letters left hanging is settled below. Both windfalls. Which of the two loves it is. Who the person is, and which direction he is walking. Each answer stands in the room that owns it, and I have not carried any of it up here to be admired first.

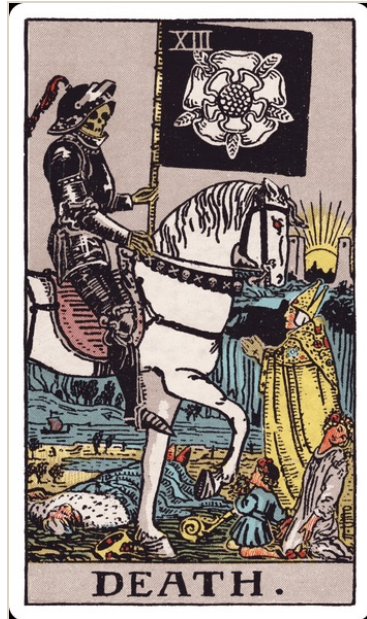
You had to say something true to yourself before you could send for this. It was not a confession, dear, and I am not going to raise it again.

One warning before you start. Parts of this will look as though they argue with each other — a card handing you ease in one room and asking you for work in the next. Read all twelve before you decide what they say. The meaning is in how they stand together, and no woman's life is consistent either.

HOUSE 1

yourself

The cosmos has guided your choice to the Nameless One, a card of an ending already under way



THE NAMELESS ONE

*an ending already decided, coming
at walking pace*

The veil or mask of life is perpetuated in change, transformation and passage from lower to higher, and this is more fitly represented in the rectified Tarot by one of the apocalyptic visions than by the crude notion of the reaping skeleton. Behind it lies the whole world of ascent in the spirit. The mysterious horseman moves slowly, bearing a black banner emblazoned with the Mystic Rose, which signifies life. Between two pillars on the verge of the horizon there shines the sun of immortality. The horseman carries no visible weapon, but king and child and maiden fall before him, while a prelate with clasped hands awaits his end. The natural transit of man to the next stage of his being either is or may be one form of his progress.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

The rider comes at a walk. Black armour, a white horse, no hurry in it — and not a scythe or a blade anywhere in those hands. He carries a flag instead, black, with one white rose on it.

Something in your life is finished, and you knew it before anybody told you. You said it to yourself plainly and did not take it back. I will give you that, because most women I read for spend a year refusing to.

Strength sits opposite you, in your seventh — you with your hands on something that will not settle, holding it quiet. You have been doing that holding on both sides. Only one side is yours.

The bishop in the horse's path stands with his hands together and does not move, and the rider comes on anyway.

So stop tidying it. This week, say the thing is over to the one person who will not argue you back out of it.

what you own

The celestial wisdom has guided your selection to the Wheel of Fortune, a card of luck turning from outside her



THE WHEEL OF FORTUNE

*a change that comes from outside
and does not ask*

I have presented Typhon in his serpent form. The four Living Creatures of Ezekiel occupy the angles of the card. The symbolic picture stands for the perpetual motion of a fluidic universe and for the flux of human life. The Sphinx is the equilibrium therein. The transliteration of Taro as Rota is inscribed on the wheel, counterchanged with the letters of the Divine Name—to shew that Providence is implied through all. But this is the Divine intention within, and the similar intention without is exemplified by the four Living Creatures. Sometimes the sphinx is represented couchant on a pedestal above, which defrauds the symbolism by stultifying the essential idea of stability amidst movement. Behind the general notion expressed in the symbol there lies the denial of chance and the fatality which is implied therein.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

On top of the wheel a sphinx lies still with a sword laid flat across it. It is not turning anything. It rests above the wheel and keeps its blade quiet while the snake slides down one side and the dog-headed one climbs the other.

Your money moves without being pushed by you, and it moves upward.

The first windfall arrives as money already owed — a sum sitting in someone else's hands until a person you have not met signs it off. A settlement, a back-payment, a claim finally

paid. The Fool in your eighth says the same thing from the other end: it comes through a stranger's decision, not your effort.

Which jug is being filled, dear? The one you keep. Money that is still there at the end of the month.

Read the wheel as luck and the letter goes unanswered, and the amount shrinks.

Leave this room and the money arrives and drains straight out again, unaccounted.

what you say, and who you say it to

The cosmic alignment has guided your choice to the Sun, a card of being heard plainly, in daylight



THE SUN

*seen plainly, in daylight, nothing to
work out*

The naked child mounted on a white horse and displaying a red standard has been mentioned already as the better symbolism connected with this card. It is the destiny of the Supernatural East and the great and holy light which goes before the endless procession of humanity, coming out from the walled garden of the sensitive life and passing on the journey home. The card signifies, therefore, the transit from the manifest light of this world, represented by the glorious sun of earth, to the light of the world to come, which goes before aspiration and is typified by the heart of a child. The sun is that of consciousness in the spirit—the direct as the antithesis of the reflected light. The characteristic type of humanity has become a little child therein.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

A low grey wall runs right across the card, and the horse is already out in front of it, standing on open ground. Nobody climbed that wall. The child is simply past it, bareback, both arms open, a red flag streaming out sideways.

You are being heard better than you believe you are. The one you keep drafting messages to has already understood you.

This card does not accuse you of hiding, and it does not say your quiet has cost you anything with anyone. It says what you put into words now lands the way you meant it — nothing to decode, nothing between the lines.

Judgment stands opposite in your ninth: the thing you hold and would not defend out loud is precisely the thing that survives being said flat.

So send the short one. Not the softened draft — and I won't pretend the softened one reads better, dear, because it does not.

Daylight is free in this room, and it stays only while you go on saying things the first time.

HOUSE 4

home, and what you came from

Your choice has been guided to the Hierophant, a card of the rule you were handed



THE HIEROPHANT

*the proper way of doing it, and
what it costs to belong*

He wears the triple crown and is seated between two pillars, but they are not those of the Temple which is guarded by the High Priestess. In his left hand he holds a sceptre terminating in the triple cross, and with his right hand he gives the well-known ecclesiastical sign which is called that of esotericism, distinguishing between the manifest and concealed part of doctrine. At his feet are the crossed keys, and two priestly ministers in albs kneel before him. He has been usually called the Pope. He is the ruling power of external religion, as the High Priestess is the prevailing genius of the esoteric, withdrawn power. He symbolizes all things that are righteous and sacred on the manifest side.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

The staff in his left hand carries three crossbars, the top one shortest — a rule passed down through three hands before it ever reached the floor of that room. He holds it. He did not make it.

Your home runs on somebody else's rule, and you have never once voted on it.

I mean something plain. The order you do things in on a Sunday. The way your voice changes when a certain relative telephones. The one room in the house nobody sits in.

None of that came from you. You kept it because keeping it was easier than being the one who stopped it.

The Empress in your tenth is growing something outward, in public, and she is being paid for out of this room. Standing kept up, home kept quiet.

I won't call that peace, dear.

The two keys lie crossed on the floor at his feet, one gold, one silver. Neither of the kneeling men reaches for them.

So the fourth is a rule you inherited and never got a vote on. Now the one room in this spread where somebody walks in from outside it, asking nobody's permission at all.

romance, and what delights you

The cosmic forces have guided your selection to the Magician, a card of everything already in your hands



THE MAGICIAN

*you already have what the job
needs*

A youthful figure in the robe of a magician, having the countenance of divine Apollo. Above his head is the mysterious sign of the Holy Spirit, the sign of life, forming the figure 8 in a horizontal position. About his waist is a serpent-cincture, the serpent appearing to devour its own tail. In the Magician's right hand is a wand raised towards heaven, while the left hand is pointing to the earth. This dual sign shews the descent of grace, virtue and light, drawn from things above and derived to things below. On the table in front of the Magician are the symbols of the four Tarot suits, signifying the elements of natural life. Beneath are roses and lilies, the flos campi and lilium convallium, changed into garden flowers, to shew the culture of aspiration.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

One hand points down at the ground while the other holds the white wand straight up, so the man runs as one line from the lilies at his feet to the air above him. Nothing on that table is ornament. Cup, coin, sword, wand — laid out, his, before he starts.

Renewal is not what you are being handed, and I won't dress it up for you. The High Priestess in your twelfth has the man already beside you halfway out of the door. There is nothing standing there to be made new.

So it is arrival. Your twin flame, a man you already know, in the second week from the day you read this. I can put a week on this room because a meeting is an event, and events land on a day. The other eleven rooms are weather.

He is not looking for you. He is halfway through an errand, already late for something, and he stops anyway — then stays past the point he meant to. Braced for lightning, you will walk straight past a man who simply does not leave.

Temperance in your eleventh says he comes to you through the people already around you. Provided you say yes this month to the one invitation you would normally decline.

And the structure you stand inside is not one you built, dear. You are being kept in it, and it sits in your fourth, where a man holds up a staff he did not make. Where you stopped choosing is your second house, what you own — you handed over deciding where your own money goes.

You already chose to stop waiting for the old one to soften. That was your decision, and you made it.

HOUSE 6

work, health, the daily grind

Your choice fell on the Chariot, a card of movement already under way



THE CHARIOT

*already moving, and it goes where
you point it*

An erect and princely figure carrying a drawn sword and corresponding, broadly speaking, to the traditional description. On the shoulders of the victorious hero are supposed to be the Urim and Thummim. He has led captivity captive; he is conquest on all planes—in the mind, in science, in progress, in certain trials of initiation. He has thus replied to the sphinx; two sphinxes thus draw his chariot. He is above all things triumph in the mind. It is to be understood that the planes of his conquest are manifest or external and not within himself; that the liberation which he effects may leave himself in the bondage of the logical understanding. He is not hereditary royalty and he is not priesthood.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

The walled town sits behind him, small already, and he has not once turned his head toward it. He left. Whatever he settled there, he settled by leaving.

Your week does not need pushing. It is already moving, and it is moving faster than you can stop it now.

Count the harness — two sphinxes, one black, one white, and no rein running from his hands to either of them. Two animals pulling, nothing steering them. Your job and your body are both under way, and you pointed them so long ago that you no longer check where.

I won't call that a virtue, dear.

The High Priestess sits still in your twelfth, between her two pillars. Your days run at this speed because you are not looking at what she is keeping.

So stop one thing this week. Not the biggest — the one nobody will notice has gone.

Where were you going, when you first pointed yourself this way?

HOUSE 7

who you are bound to

Your choice has fallen on Strength, a card of holding something quiet by hand



STRENGTH

*holding something strong by hand,
gently, every day*

A woman, over whose head there broods the same symbol of life which we have seen in the card of the Magician, is closing the jaws of a lion. The only point in which this design differs from the conventional presentations is that her beneficent fortitude has already subdued the lion, which is being led by a chain of flowers. Fortitude, in one of its most exalted aspects, is connected with the Divine Mystery of Union, and with the strength which resides in contemplation. These higher meanings are intimated in a concealed manner by the chain of flowers, which signifies the sweet yoke and the light burden of Divine Law. There is one aspect in which the lion signifies the passions, and she who is called Strength is the higher nature in its liberation.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

One grey hill sits far behind her, and the ground between her and it is bare — no road, no house, nobody walking toward her. She is doing this on her own.

The man you are bound to is not improving. You are the one keeping him level.

You drop your voice before he has raised his. You answer the same question again without saying it is the second time. You read the room he is in from the doorway, before you step into it.

That is work, dear, and it comes round again in the morning.

The rider in your first house walks on while the bishop stands in his path with his hands pressed together, and you told me the thing was finished. Your hands are still on the jaws. The Magician in your fifth is bringing a man toward you, so understand what you are holding when he arrives.

The flower chain round her waist runs on and loops over the lion's neck.

Everything up to here you have been holding up yourself. The eighth is the one room where the good thing is being carried toward you by somebody else's hands.

HOUSE 8

what is hidden, and what comes through others

The cosmos has turned your hand to the Fool, a card of money that arrives unrecorded



THE FOOL

*a step taken before you can see
where it lands*

With light step, as if earth and its trammels had little power to restrain him, a young man in gorgeous vestments pauses at the brink of a precipice; he surveys the blue distance before him—its expanse of sky rather than the prospect below. His act of eager walking is still indicated, though he is stationary at the given moment; his dog is still bounding. The edge which opens on the depth has no terror; it is as if angels were waiting to uphold him. He has a rose in one hand and in the other a costly wand, from which depends over his right shoulder a wallet curiously embroidered. He is a prince of the other world on his travels through this one. He is the spirit in search of experience.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

The marks worked into that wallet never make a word. Someone stitched them there and left them unreadable — a bag carrying something with no paperwork behind it.

I promised you two windfalls. This is the second, and I am paying it here.

It is not the settlement sitting in your second house, signed off by a stranger and dropped into an account. This one comes through a woman at the edge of your circle who has been saying your name in rooms you were not standing in. Temperance in your eleventh agrees: what is good this season reaches you through people already near you.

It changes your love life because nobody in your fourth house gets to ask where it came from.
It pays for a door.

You have already noticed her doing it, dear. You decided you were flattering yourself.

Thank her plainly this week, and let her tell you what she has been arranging.

what you believe

The celestial wisdom has guided your selection to Judgment, a card of one old thing called up for an answer



JUDGMENT

*something from your past calling
for an answer now*

The great angel is here encompassed by clouds, but he blows his bannered trumpet, and the cross as usual is displayed on the banner. The dead are rising from their tombs—a woman on the right, a man on the left hand, and between them their child, whose back is turned. But in this card there are more than three who are restored. It should be noted that all the figures are as one in the wonder, adoration and ecstasy expressed by their attitudes. It is the card which registers the accomplishment of the great work of transformation in answer to the summons of the Supernal—which summons is heard and answered from within. It has been called truly in the past a card of eternal life.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

A square of white cloth hangs off that trumpet, a red cross laid flat across it, and nothing about it is blowing — there is no wind anywhere on this card. It is a claim being made, not a flag being waved.

Something you settled about yourself a long time ago is standing up out of the water now and waiting for you to say it in the open.

You believe good things have to be paid for.

So you send the message and then go back over it. You add the line apologising for the length. You accept help and then find something to do for the person before they can call it a favour.

I won't call that good manners, dear.

The Sun in your third has you being understood the first time you speak. That is bought out of this room — you say it flat, then settle up afterwards, privately.

The child between those two coffins has its arms straight out and asks nobody's leave.

Leave this belief where it stands and the money coming and the man who stays get charged to your account. You will find a way to owe for both.

So ask what you have been quietly paying for. Then look at what your name is already worth outside your own front door.

your standing

Your choice has led you to the Empress, a card of a ripe crop still uncut



THE EMPRESS

*something growing that needs
feeding, not starting*

A stately figure, seated, having rich vestments and royal aspect, as of a daughter of heaven and earth. Her diadem is of twelve stars, gathered in a cluster. The symbol of Venus is on the shield which rests near her. A field of corn is ripening in front of her, and beyond there is a fall of water. The sceptre which she bears is surmounted by the globe of this world. She is the inferior Garden of Eden, the Earthly Paradise. She is above all things universal fecundity and the outer sense of the Word. In another order of ideas, the card of the Empress signifies the door or gate by which an entrance is obtained into this life, as into the Garden of Venus.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

Her arm is raised with the globe on the end of that sceptre, held up over an open field where nobody is standing to watch her do it. She holds it up anyway.

The people who decide things about you have already decided well. What has not happened is one of them saying it to your face.

You do what you said you would do, on the day you said it, and you have never once traded on that. The corn in front of her is ripe because of it — and not one stalk of it is cut yet.

The Hierophant in your fourth is the bill for this field. Your name goes up outside while at home you go quiet.

I won't have you keep paying it that way, dear.

So this month tell one person in that house, plainly, what you were thanked for. This field feeds you, and it wants the harvest said out loud where you sleep.

your circle

Your selection has fallen to Temperance, a card of two circles becoming one



TEMPERANCE

*two things becoming one, at the
speed of a season*

A winged angel, with the sign of the sun upon his forehead and on his breast the square and triangle of the septenary. I speak of him in the masculine sense, but the figure is neither male nor female. It is held to be pouring the essences of life from chalice to chalice. It has one foot upon the earth and one upon waters. A direct path goes up to certain heights on the verge of the horizon, and above there is a great light, through which a crown is seen vaguely. Hereof is some part of the Secret of Eternal Life. It is called Temperance fantastically, because, when the rule of it obtains in our consciousness, it tempers, combines and harmonises the psychic and material natures.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

The winged one is not filling a cup. The same water goes out of the high cup into the low one and comes back, over and over, and it crosses the gap on a slant no falling water takes.

Nobody goes quiet on you this season. What happens instead is slower and better: two people who know you and do not know each other end up in the same room.

The Magician in your fifth is standing at the end of that. He does not arrive out of nowhere — he arrives down a road your friends are laying without telling you, one introduction at a time.

I won't pretend it pours itself, dear. If she takes the good news and lets three invitations go unanswered, the two cups stay separate, and the man on his errand walks a street she is never standing on.

Yellow flowers grow at the water's edge, right beside the foot already in the pool.

Your circle is walking a man toward you. Your twelfth is where you find out what has to be set down before he gets to the door.

HOUSE 12

what is being kept from you

And your twelfth card is the High Priestess, a card of what you already know



THE HIGH PRIESTESS

*something known and not yet said
out loud*

She has the lunar crescent at her feet, a horned diadem on her head, with a globe in the middle place, and a large solar cross on her breast. The scroll in her hands is inscribed with the word TORA. It is partly covered by her mantle, to shew that some things are implied and some spoken. She is seated between the white and black pillars of the mystic Temple, and the veil of the Temple is behind her: it is embroidered with palms and pomegranates. The vestments are flowing and gauzy, and the mantle suggests light—a shimmering radiance. She is really the Secret Church, the House which is of God and man. She is the spiritual Bride and Mother. She is, in fine, the Queen of the borrowed light.

A. E. WAITE, *THE PICTORIAL KEY TO THE TAROT*, 1911

Two pillars, one black, one white, a single letter cut into each — B on the dark, J on the pale — and she sits between them saying nothing to either side.

What is being kept from you is not being kept by him. You have it.

The person is the one still here, and he has already begun leaving. Not somebody from before, walking back in. Other people can see it now; that is how far along it is.

The piece you keep talking yourself out of is the true one. He decided a while ago. The rest — the reasons you build out of his quiet — is paint you put on yourself, and staring longer into

that quiet only adds more of it.

This card does not call you foolish for missing it. Half that scroll is under her mantle by choice.

Strength in your seventh has you keeping him level with both hands. Put them down this week, dear.

You already decided this was over. You did not take it back.

Now what the twelve say together, which no single one of them said.

Money, work and love all move toward you from outside, and not one of them is waiting on effort. The only labour asked of you in this whole spread is letting go of something you are holding up with both arms.

The twelfth comes first, and it is the condition of the other two. Your first house has the rider walking on past a man who will not move — you said it was finished before I did. Put your hands down and the fifth arrives on schedule and the money in your second stays where it lands. Hold on, and the man in your fifth still comes, but he finds you occupied, and the money passes through you.

And you stop hearing things last. Twice in this spread, people are deciding well about you in rooms you are not in. From here you find out while it is still being arranged, not afterwards.

The first sign is small and countable. Inside five to seven days, someone will tell you your name came up — that a woman mentioned you to somebody, favourably, without your asking. Mark the day.

I have dated one room, your fifth, because a meeting is a thing that happens on an afternoon. The other eleven I have not dated and will not pretend to. The two months are when the movement starts, not a promise it is all finished by then. Some of this will be open inside a fortnight. The slow rooms are slow because of the cards standing in them, and women lose these things by reading slow as no.

This week: the invitation you were going to decline politely. Accept it.

And now the second part, dear — this one is yours to keep

When you have read your twelve properly — all of them, more than once — there is a second thing I want to give you, and it costs you nothing but a minute a night.

I said in my letter that the difference is not whether things happen to you. It is whether they happen to you from behind.

This is the practice that makes the difference. It is the only one I give away.

What it is

Twenty-eight nights. One line a night. That is the whole of it.

Each night before you sleep, you write down **one thing you noticed that day that was different from the day before.**

Not how you felt. Not what you hope. What you *noticed*. Something someone said that they don't usually say. A message that came at an odd hour. A silence where there is normally noise. The way a room went when you walked into it.

One line. Ordinary handwriting, ordinary paper, no ceremony. If nothing was different, write *nothing was different* — that is a real entry and you will want it later.

The reason is simple and it is not mystical, dear. Your twelfth house is holding something unsaid, and things like that are never invisible. They are only ever *unrecorded*. A woman notices eleven small wrong notes across a fortnight, forgets ten of them, and is genuinely astonished by the eleventh. She was told eleven times. She just had nowhere to put it.

The ledger is somewhere to put it.

The four turns

Nights 1 to 7 — the first turn. Just notice. Don't interpret, don't join anything up, and above all don't act on it. This week you are only training the eye. Write the line and close the book.

Your reading said the first sign shows itself inside five to seven days. It lands in this turn. You will not necessarily know it when it arrives — that is exactly why you are writing it down.

Nights 8 to 14 — the second turn. Same one line, and add a second only when you genuinely have one. By now you will start wanting to explain what you're writing. Resist it for

one more week. An explanation written the same night is almost always the explanation you already believed that morning.

Night 15 — the read-back. This is the night the practice pays. Do not write anything first. Sit down and read your fourteen lines in one sitting, in order, start to finish.

Something will come up off the page that was not visible on any single night. It always does. That is the whole reason for the fourteen — not one of those lines is worth much alone and together they are a pattern.

Then write your line for the fifteenth night, and write underneath it what you saw in the fourteen.

Nights 15 to 21 — the third turn. Now you know what you have been noticing, so notice *that*. Your attention has something to point at, and you will find you catch things on the day now instead of three days late.

Nights 22 to 28 — the fourth turn. Keep writing, and this week let yourself act on what you have found. Ask the question. Decline the thing. Say the sentence you have been keeping. You have three weeks of evidence behind you and you are no longer guessing.

On the twenty-eighth night, read the whole ledger through.

The two love weeks

In the weeks your reading named, pay particular attention to the people you come across.

Your fifth house has something already in motion toward you, and your reading has said in its own room whether it arrives as a stranger or as someone already in the frame. Either way it comes in small — which is precisely the kind of thing the eye skips and the ledger catches.

Someone you know may reappear in these weeks. Someone in the frame may step forward in it. Write it down on the night, in the ordinary way, even when it seems far too small to mean anything.

Especially then. The ones that matter almost always look too small on the night.

If nothing happens

Then you run the twenty-eight again.

I mean that plainly and not as a consolation. Some women's first cycle is all noise — four weeks of *nothing was different* — and their second cycle is the one that shows the shape. The practice is not a spell that either works or doesn't. It is an eye being trained, and eyes take a while.

The second twenty-eight is easier than the first, and it is the one where the read-back on the fifteenth night stops you cold.

And that is the gift

Keep the book. Not for me — I don't want to see it, and I'd rather you wrote freely than wrote something you'd be willing to show a reader.

Keep it because in eight weeks you are going to want to know whether you saw it coming.

You did. It will be on the page in your own handwriting, three weeks before it happened, in a line you thought was too small to matter.

That is what it is to stop finding out last.

These twelve were laid for you and for nobody else. The writing is assisted — I use a machine to help me put a reading into words. The draw is real and it is yours.

Evelyn